

Chapter 4 — The Mughals (16th to 17th Century)

The one-line point: The Mughals did what nobody since Ashoka had managed — **held nearly the whole subcontinent, and made it stick**. The machinery that did it was the **mansabdari system**, and the ideology that held it together was ***sulh-i kul***. Both are heavily asked.

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Syllabus Classification

Field	Value
Subject	History → Medieval India
Sub-discipline	Mughal Empire — political, administrative & economic history
Period	1526 – 1707 (decline to 1750, → Ch.8)
Prelims (GS Paper I)	<i>History of India</i> → mansabdari, zabt, sources, rulers
Mains (GS Paper I)	★ ★ ★ Administration; <i>sulh-i kul</i> and religious policy; agrarian crisis ; Mughal culture
Also feeds	Polity/Ethics ★ ★ ★ (<i>sulh-i kul</i> — the single best pre-modern Indian example of state-sponsored pluralism), Art & Culture ★ ★ (Red Fort, miniatures, → Ch.9 supplement), Economy ★ ★ (revenue, inequality, investment), Indian Society (gender — Nur Jahan)
Weightage	★ ★ ★ ★ ★ — among the highest in medieval India
Overlaps with	Ch.3 (Sher Shah → Akbar), Ch.8 (the decline), Ch.9 supplement (architecture)

 **Medieval India → Mughal.** For Mains, ***sulh-i kul*** is your highest-value single idea in this entire book — it serves GS1 (culture), GS2 (secularism's Indian antecedents) and GS4 (tolerance) alike.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this chapter you should be able to:

- ☐ **Explain** the Mughals' **double descent** and **why they rejected the name "Mughal"**. ★
- ☐ **Narrate** Babur's path from Ferghana to Kabul (**1504**) to Delhi (**1526**).
- ☐ **Distinguish primogeniture from coparcenary** and say which the Mughals followed. ★
- ☐ **Explain** Mughal–Rajput policy, naming the **Sisodiyas**, ***watan jagir***, and the marriage alliances.
- ☐ **Define** ***mansabdar****, ***mansab***, ***zat***, ***sawar***, ****jagir*** and explain how the system worked. ★ ★
- ☐ **Explain** the difference between a ***jagirdar*** and a ***muqti***. ★
- ☐ **Explain the jagirdari crisis** — why it emerged and what it did to the peasantry. ★ ★
- ☐ **Describe** the ***zabt*** system, name **Todar Mal**, and state where it did *not* work. ★
- ☐ **Define** ***zamindar*** in Mughal usage and explain the zamindar–peasant alliance in revolt.
- ☐ **Describe** the ***Akbar Nama*** and ***Ain-i Akbari*** and what makes the latter unusual. ★
- ☐ **Explain** ***sulh-i kul*** and quote Jahangir's description. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Describe** **Nur Jahan's** position and the evidence for it (coins, *farman*, seals). ★

- ☐ **Cite the inequality statistic** from Shah Jahan's reign and explain its economic consequence. ★★

Start Here: Why the Red Fort Still Matters

"Today the Prime Minister of India addresses the nation on Independence Day from the ramparts of the Red Fort in Delhi, the residence of the Mughal emperors."

NCERT opens with this, and it's a deliberate point. The Mughals **"imposed structures of administration and ideas of governance that outlasted their rule, leaving a political legacy that succeeding rulers of the subcontinent could not ignore."**

THE ACHIEVEMENT, STATED PRECISELY

Ruling a territory as large as the subcontinent, with such a DIVERSITY of people and cultures, was an extremely difficult task.

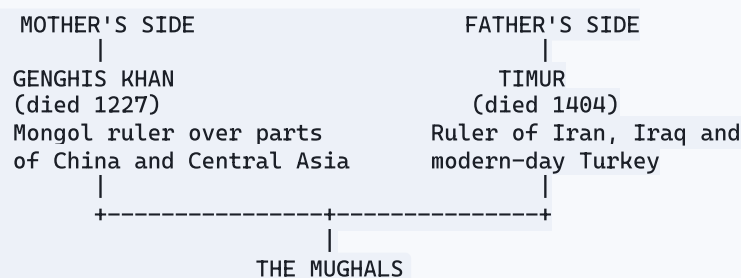
Quite IN CONTRAST TO THEIR PREDECESSORS, the Mughals created an empire and accomplished what had hitherto seemed possible only for SHORT PERIODS of time.

From the latter half of the 16th century they expanded from AGRA and DELHI, until in the 17th century they controlled NEARLY ALL of the subcontinent.

🔑 **The word doing the work is "diversity".** Many empires have been large. The Mughal problem was governing **many religions, languages, castes and regional elites at once** — and the answer they arrived at (*sulh-i kul* plus a deliberately mixed nobility) is what makes them interesting rather than merely big.

1 Who Were the Mughals? ★★

Double descent



★ Why they hated the word "Mughal"

Reason

Genghis Khan's memory was associated with the massacre of innumerable people

It was also **linked with the Uzbeks — their Mongol competitors** (and the very people who had driven Babur from his ancestral throne)

By contrast, they were PROUD of their TIMURID ancestry — not least because **their great ancestor had captured Delhi** (Timur's invasion of 1398).

★ A lovely detail worth remembering: "They celebrated their genealogy pictorially, **each ruler getting a picture made of Timur and himself**." Dynastic legitimacy asserted through **painting** — a reminder that Mughal art was political instrument as much as decoration.

🔗 Exercise question straight from the book: "Why did the Mughals emphasise their Timurid and not their Mongol descent?" You now have the two-part answer.

🐎 Babur

Fact	Detail
Became ruler at	12 years old
Lost his throne	Forced to leave his ancestral throne (Ferghana) due to invasion by another Mongol group, the UZBEGS ★
Then	After years of wandering , he seized KABUL in 1504 ★
1526 ★ ★ ★	Defeated Ibrahim Lodi at Panipat and captured Delhi and Agra

🔗 1526 is the hinge date of the book — the Delhi Sultanate (Ch.3) ends and the Mughal Empire begins. Cannons were an important addition to sixteenth-century warfare, and Babur used them effectively.

👑 The emperors — the sequence to know

Ruler	Reign
Babur	1526 – 1530
Humayun	1530 – 1540, and again 1555 – 1556
(<i>Sher Shah Suri interregnum</i>)	1540 – 1555 (Ch.3)
★ AKBAR	1556 – 1605
Jahangir	1605 – 1627
Shah Jahan	1627 – 1658
★ Aurangzeb	1658 – 1707

2 ★ ★ Traditions of Succession

System	Meaning	Did the Mughals use it?
PRIMOGENITURE	The eldest son inherits his father's estate	✗ NO
COPARCENARY INHERITANCE ★	Division of the inheritance amongst ALL the sons — the Mughal and Timurid custom	✓ YES

🎯 **The consequence, which NCERT leaves you to work out:** if every son has a claim, **every succession is a potential civil war**. And that is exactly what happened — Aurangzeb reached the throne by defeating and killing his brothers and imprisoning Shah Jahan.

📖 **Compare with Chapter 3's instability.** The Sultanate's problem was that *loyalty didn't transfer across reigns*; the Mughal problem was that *the succession rule guaranteed multiple valid claimants*. **Two different empires, two different unsolved continuity problems.** That comparison makes a strong Mains paragraph.

NCERT's own question is worth answering: *which is fairer, primogeniture or coparcenary?* Coparcenary is more equitable **between sons** but destabilising **for the state**.

3 ★ ★ Mughal Relations with Other Rulers

The Mughals **campaign**ed constantly against rulers who refused to accept their authority. But as they became powerful, **many rulers also joined them voluntarily**.

The Rajputs — the model case

Pattern
Many married their daughters into Mughal families and received high positions
But many resisted as well

★ **The Sisodiya Rajputs of Mewar** refused to accept Mughal authority for a long time. **Once defeated, however:**

They were HONOURABLY TREATED by the Mughals, given their lands back as assignments (WATAN JAGIR).

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"The careful balance between DEFEATING but NOT HUMILIATING their opponents enabled the Mughals to extend their influence over many kings and chieftains."

★ ★ "Defeating but not humiliating" is the single most quotable phrase in this chapter. It is a genuine statecraft principle: a defeated enemy who keeps his lands, honour and a place in your system becomes an **asset**; one who is humiliated becomes a **permanent insurgency**.

🎯 **Deploy it in GS4 (conflict resolution, magnanimity in victory), in GS2 (federalism and accommodation of regional elites), and in Essay.** It is also the direct contrast with Aurangzeb's later, harsher approach — which is part of the explanation for Mughal decline in Ch.8.

★ **Marriage alliances — the two examples NCERT gives:**

Emperor	His mother
JAHANGIR	A KACHHWAHA princess, daughter of the Rajput ruler of AMBER (modern-day Jaipur)
SHAH JAHAN	A RATHOR princess, daughter of the Rajput ruler of MARWAR (Jodhpur)

🔔 **Learn the pairings:** Kachhwaha–Amber/Jaipur; Rathor–Marwar/Jodhpur; **Sisodiya–Mewar** (the resisters). These appear as match-the-following in the textbook itself, which is a strong hint about how they get tested.

4 ★ ★ ★ Mansabdars and Jagirdars — The Core Machinery

A deliberately mixed nobility

From a SMALL NUCLEUS of Turkish nobles (TURANIS) the Mughals expanded recruitment to include:

IRANIANS	INDIAN MUSLIMS	AFGHANS
RAJPUTS	MARATHAS	and other groups

Those who joined Mughal service were enrolled as MANSABDARS.

🎯 NCERT's exercise question asks why the Mughals recruited from diverse backgrounds rather than just Turanis and Iranis. The answer: an empire of that diversity could only be held by **co-opting regional elites into the imperial service**, giving them a stake in its survival. **A nobility drawn from one ethnic group would have had no reach into Rajasthan, the Deccan or Bengal.** This is *sulh-i kul* expressed as personnel policy.

The terms — learn these precisely ★ ★ ★

Term	Meaning
MANSAB	A position or rank
MANSABDAR	An individual who holds a mansab
ZAT ★	The numerical value determining rank and salary . The higher the zat, the more prestigious the position and the larger the salary
SAWAR ★	The number of cavalrymen a mansabdar was required to maintain
JAGIR ★	The revenue assignment given to a mansabdar as salary
JAGIRDAR	The holder of a jagir

★ Zat in practice:

- Nobles with a **zat of 5,000** ranked higher than those of **1,000**
- In **Akbar's reign** there were **29 mansabdars with a rank of 5,000 zat**
- **By Aurangzeb's reign the number had increased to 79** ★ (NCERT asks: would this have meant more expenditure for the state? — **yes**, and it's the seed of the crisis below)

🐎 The military obligation

The MANSABDAR must maintain a specified number of SAWAR (cavalrymen). The process:

1. He **BRINGS** his cavalrymen **FOR REVIEW**
2. They are **REGISTERED**
3. Their **HORSES ARE BRANDED**
4. He then **RECEIVES MONEY** to pay them as salary

 **Steps 2 and 3 are an anti-fraud mechanism, and a good one.** Registering the men and **branding the horses** prevents a mansabdar from borrowing the same troopers (or horses) to pass multiple inspections, or from claiming pay for soldiers who don't exist. **It is verification of a claimed resource before disbursing payment against it** — the *dagh* (branding) and *chehra* (descriptive roll) system, and it dates back to Alauddin Khalji.

★ Jagirdar vs Muqti — a distinction UPSC likes

	MUQTI (Ch.3, Sultanate)	JAGIRDAR (Mughal)
Held	An iqta	A jagir
Residence	Resided in and administered his iqta	★ Most did NOT reside in or administer their jagir
Revenue	Collected it himself	Collected by his servants , while he served in some other part of the country
Rights	Governance + revenue	★ Only rights to the revenue

★ **This is a real conceptual advance.** By separating **where you are paid from** and **where you serve**, the Mughals broke the link between an officer and a territorial power base. A jagirdar could not build a regional following in a district he never visited. **It is the *iqta* idea taken one step further toward a salaried bureaucracy.**

★ ★ ★ The Jagirdari Crisis

This is the chapter's most important causal chain, and it feeds directly into Chapter 8.

AKBAR'S REIGN

Jagirs **CAREFULLY ASSESSED** so their revenues were **ROUGHLY EQUAL** to the mansabdar's salary

AURANGZEB'S REIGN

Actual revenue collected was **OFTEN LESS** than the granted sum

HUGE INCREASE in the NUMBER of mansabdars

-> A LONG WAIT before a mansabdar received a jagir
-> A SHORTAGE of jagirs

Manv jagirdars tried to **EXTRACT AS MUCH REVENUE AS POSSIBLE** while they had a jagir

Aurangzeb was **UNABLE TO CONTROL** these developments in the last years of his reign

"THE PEASANTRY THEREFORE **SUFFERED TREMENDOUSLY.**"

 **Why this is such good exam material:** it is a **structural** explanation of imperial decline, not a moral one. Nobody had to be wicked. **More nobles + less revenue per jagir + short tenure = rational short-term extraction.** The incentive to strip an asset you will hold briefly is exactly what you'd predict.

 It's a **tragedy-of-the-commons with a rotation policy attached** — the rotation that protected the state from regional power bases (above) simultaneously **removed any incentive to preserve the productive capacity of the land.** **The same design feature that solved one problem created another.** Say that in a Mains answer and it lands.

5 ★ ★ Zabt and Zamindars

The revenue base

The main source of income available to Mughal rulers was tax on the produce of the peasantry.

In most places, peasants paid taxes **through the rural elites** — the **headman or the local chieftain**.

★ **ZAMINDAR** — the Mughals used **one term** to describe **all intermediaries**, whether **local headmen of villages** or **powerful chieftains**.

🎯 The flattening of a hugely varied reality into one administrative category is itself significant — a village headman and a regional chieftain were very different people with very different power, but the Mughal state dealt with both through a single legal-fiscal label. **This is a state simplifying society in order to govern it**, and it's a strong point for an answer on state capacity.

★ ★ The *zabt* system

Element	Detail
Who	TODAR MAL , Akbar's revenue minister ★
What he did	Carried out a careful survey of crop yields, prices and areas cultivated for a 10-year period
The unit	Each province was divided into revenue circles , each with its own schedule of revenue rates for individual crops ★
The name	This revenue system was known as ZABT
★ Where it worked	Only where Mughal administrators could survey the land and keep very careful accounts
★ Where it did NOT	Provinces such as GUJARAT and BENGAL

★ That last row is the most-missed fact in the chapter and a favourite trap. *Zabt* was **not** empire-wide. It required survey capacity, and where the state lacked it, other systems were used. **Never write "the Mughals used zabt throughout the empire."**

🔗 **Note the lineage again:** careful survey and measurement → **Sher Shah** → **Todar Mal under Akbar**. Ch.3's closing point, delivered.

✂ Zamindars and revolt

In some areas **the zamindars exercised a great deal of power**. Exploitation by Mughal administrators could drive them into rebellion — and when **zamindars and peasants of the same caste allied** in rebelling against Mughal authority, the result was serious.

★ "These peasant revolts challenged the stability of the Mughal Empire from the end of the seventeenth century."

🎯 **Note what makes the alliance dangerous: shared CASTE.** Caste solidarity cut across the fiscal hierarchy that the state relied on — the intermediary and the taxpayer made common cause. **This is a key mechanism behind the 18th-century collapse (Ch.8)**, and it connects to the Jat and Maratha risings.

6 ★★ The Sources: *Akbar Nama* and *Ain-i Akbari*

Akbar ordered **ABUL FAZL**, one of his close friends and courtiers, to write a history of his reign.

Volume	Contents
Volume 1	Akbar's ancestors
Volume 2	The events of Akbar's reign
Volume 3 = <i>AIN-I AKBARI</i> ★	Akbar's administration, household, army, the revenues and the geography of his empire — plus rich details about the traditions and culture of the people living in India

★ What makes the *Ain-i Akbari* remarkable:

*"The most interesting aspect about the Ain-i Akbari is its rich **STATISTICAL DETAILS** about things as diverse as **crops, yields, prices, wages and revenues.**"*

📖 **This is essentially an imperial dataset** — a systematic, quantified account of an empire's economy, compiled in the 1590s. For historians it is extraordinary, because it allows **quantitative** economic history of a pre-modern Indian state, which almost no other source permits.

⚠️ **But apply Chapter 1's caution:** Abul Fazl was Akbar's **close friend and courtier**, writing an official history. The statistics are invaluable; the **evaluations of Akbar are not neutral**. Same rule as the *tawarikh* and the *prashastis*.

7 ★★ ★ *SULH-I KUL* — "Universal Peace"

The most important idea in the chapter, and possibly in the book.

Akbar's nobles included **Turanis, Iranis, Indian Muslims, Afghans, Rajputs and Marathas** — men of many faiths. He held **debates with religious scholars** of different traditions, and with **Abul Fazl's** help framed the idea of ***sulh-i kul*** so that he could **govern a society composed of many religions, cultures and castes**.

★★ Jahangir's description of his father's policy — worth knowing closely:

*"As in the wide expanse of the divine compassion there is room for all classes and the followers of all creeds, so ... in his Imperial dominions, which on all sides were limited only by the sea, **there was room for the professors of opposite religions, and for beliefs, good and bad, and the road to intolerance was closed. Sunnis and Shias met in one mosque and Christians and Jews in one church to pray.** He consistently followed the principle of 'universal peace' (*sulh-i kul*)."*

 **Read the two underlined moves carefully, because they are what make this quotable:**

1. **"beliefs, good and bad"** — tolerance is extended **even to beliefs the ruler considers wrong**. That is a far stronger claim than tolerating what you approve of. It is close to the modern liberal position.
2. **"the road to intolerance was closed"** — intolerance is framed as **the thing the state acts against**, rather than a private attitude the state ignores.

★ ★ ★ **This is the single best pre-modern Indian citation for:**

- **GS2** — the indigenous antecedents of Indian secularism (alongside Ashoka's **Rock Edict XII**, Class 6 Ch.7)
- **GS4 Ethics** — tolerance, pluralism, the ethics of governing diversity
- **GS1** — Mughal cultural policy
- **Essay** — unity in diversity, composite culture

 **Pair it with Ashoka's RE XII.** Ashoka argued that attacking another sect **harms your own**; Akbar's court argued that the state must **close the road to intolerance**. Two emperors, 1,900 years apart, reaching compatible conclusions about governing a plural society. **That pairing, deployed in an introduction, is genuinely strong.**

★ **Nur Jahan**

Fact	Detail
Name	MEHRUNNISA
Married	Emperor JAHANGIR in 1611
Title received	NUR JAHAN
★ Coins	As a mark of honour, Jahangir struck SILVER COINS bearing his own titles on one side and on the other the inscription "struck in the name of the Queen Begum, Nur Jahan"
★ <i>Farman</i>	She issued farmans (royal orders) under her own seals
Square seal	"Command of her most Sublime and Elevated Majesty Nur Jahan Padshah Begum "
Round seal	"by the sun of Shah Jahangir she became as brilliant as the moon; may Nur Jahan Padshah be the lady of the age"

 **Why the coins and the *farman* matter as evidence:** minting coinage and issuing *farmans* are **sovereign acts**. That Nur Jahan's name appeared on both is **hard, material proof of real political authority**, not court flattery.

 **Compare with Chapter 3's queens.** Raziyya put her **father's** name on her coins to borrow legitimacy; **Nur Jahan's own name and titles appear on hers**. Rudramadevi had to pose as a man. **Three centuries, three positions — and a genuinely comparative answer for a GS1 gender question.**

9 ★★ The Empire in the 17th Century — Wealth and Its Distribution

The paradox international travellers reported

The administrative and military efficiency of the empire led to **great economic and commercial prosperity**. International travellers described it as "**the fabled land of wealth**".

But these same visitors were also appalled at the state of poverty that existed side by side with the greatest opulence. THE INEQUALITIES WERE GLARING.

★★ The statistic you should memorise

Documents from the twentieth year of Shah Jahan's reign:

The HIGHEST-RANKING mansabdars were only

445 out of a total of 8,000

= about 5.6% of all mansabdars

...and this small group received

61.5% OF THE TOTAL ESTIMATED REVENUE
OF THE EMPIRE

as salaries for themselves and their troopers.

★ "5.6% of the nobility took 61.5% of imperial revenue" is one of the most powerful single facts in the whole NCERT History series. It is precise, sourced, and immediately usable in an Economy, Society or Essay answer on inequality.

📦 The economic consequence — a genuinely sophisticated argument

Emperors and mansabdars spent a great deal of income on
SALARIES and GOODS

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This BENEFITED the artisans and peasantry who SUPPLIED
them with goods and produce

|
v

BUT: "the scale of revenue collection left VERY LITTLE FOR
INVESTMENT in the hands of the PRIMARY PRODUCERS --
the peasant and the artisan."

|
v

The POOREST lived HAND TO MOUTH and could hardly consider
investing in additional TOOLS AND SUPPLIES to
INCREASE PRODUCTIVITY

|
v

Only the WEALTHIER PEASANTRY, artisanal groups, merchants
and bankers PROFITED in this economic world.

🎯 **This is an argument about why growth did not compound**, and it is unusually sophisticated for a Class 7 book. **Extraction at that scale prevented capital formation at the bottom.** Demand existed (the elite bought a great deal), but the producers could never accumulate enough surplus to invest in productivity.

★ **Superb material for GS3 (economy) and Essay:** it is a pre-modern illustration of the argument that **high inequality suppresses productive investment** — and a direct answer to the "but the Mughal empire was fabulously rich" line. **Rich empire, poor producers, no compounding.**

📉 **And then the centre weakens**

The enormous wealth and resources commanded by the Mughal elite made them an **extremely powerful group** in the late seventeenth century. As the authority of the Mughal emperor slowly declined, **his servants emerged as powerful centres of power in the regions.** They **constituted new dynasties** and held the command of provinces like **HYDERABAD and AWADH.** Although they **continued to recognise the Mughal emperor in Delhi as their master**, by the eighteenth century the provinces **had consolidated their independent political identities.**

🔗 **That is Chapter 8 in a paragraph** — and note the mechanism: the successor states were founded **not by rebels but by the empire's own officers. The empire was not overthrown; it was inherited from the inside.**

Prelims

Topic	The exact thing to know
Mughal descent ★★	Mother's side Genghis Khan (d.1227); father's side Timur (d.1404). Rejected "Mughal" (massacre + Uzbek association); proud of Timurid
Babur ★★	Ruler at 12; driven out by Uzbeks ; Kabul 1504 ; Delhi & Agra 1526
Succession ★★	NOT primogeniture — coparcenary (division among all sons)
Sisodiyas of Mewar ★	Long resistance; then honourably treated, lands returned as watan jagir
Rajput mothers ★	Jahangir — Kachhwaha, Amber/Jaipur ; Shah Jahan — Rathor, Marwar/Jodhpur
Turani	The original Turkish nobles
Mansab* / *mansabdar ★★ ★	Rank / holder of rank
Zat ★★ ★	Numerical value fixing rank and salary ; 29 nobles at 5,000 zat under Akbar → 79 under Aurangzeb
Sawar ★★	Number of cavalrymen to be maintained; horses branded , men registered
Jagir ★★ ★	Revenue assignment as salary; jagirdars did NOT reside in or administer them
Jagirdari crisis ★★	More mansabdars + less revenue + long waits → extraction → peasantry suffered under Aurangzeb
Zabt ★★ ★	Todar Mal ; 10-year survey of yields, prices, areas; revenue circles ; NOT used in Gujarat and Bengal
Zamindar ★★	Mughal blanket term for all intermediaries — headmen and chieftains alike
Peasant revolts ★	Zamindars + peasants of the same caste allied; from the end of the 17th century
Akbar Nama ★★	Abul Fazl ; three volumes ; vol.3 = Ain-i Akbari with statistical details
Sulh-i kul ★★ ★	"Universal peace"; framed with Abul Fazl ; described by Jahangir
Nur Jahan ★★	Mehrunnisa ; married Jahangir 1611 ; silver coins in her name; issued farmans
Inequality statistic ★★	445 of 8,000 mansabdars (5.6%) took 61.5% of estimated revenue (20th year of Shah Jahan)
Successor provinces	Hyderabad and Awadh

Traps:

- "The Mughals followed primogeniture" → **FALSE**. Coparcenary
- "Jagirdars administered their jagirs like muqtis" → **FALSE**. Most **never resided there**; they held only revenue rights
- "Zabt was applied throughout the empire" → **FALSE**. Not in **Gujarat and Bengal**
- "Zat indicated the number of cavalrymen" → **FALSE**. That's **sawar**; zat fixed rank and salary
- "The Mughals proudly called themselves Mongols" → **FALSE**. They **disliked** it
- "Nur Jahan's influence is known only from later legend" → **FALSE**. Coins and farmans are contemporary material evidence

Mains

- **GS2 / GS4 / Essay** ★★ ★: **sulh-i kul** — quote Jahangir; pair with **Ashoka's Rock Edict XII**; the indigenous roots of Indian pluralism
- **Administration** ★★: mansabdari as an attempt at a **non-territorial, salaried nobility**; contrast **jagirdar** with **muqti**

- **Decline** ★ ★ ★: the **jagirdari crisis** as a structural, incentive-driven explanation — far better than "weak successors"
- **Economy/GS3** ★ ★: the 61.5% statistic and the **investment-suppression argument** — wealth without capital formation
- **Gender (GS1)** ★: Nur Jahan's coins and farmans vs Raziyya's and Rudramadevi's strategies (Ch.3)
- **Statecraft/GS4**: "*defeating but not humiliating*" as a principle of conflict resolution

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Primogeniture	Inheritance by the eldest son
Coparcenary	Division of inheritance among all sons — the Mughal custom
Mansab	A position or rank
Mansabdar	The holder of a mansab
Zat	Numerical value fixing a mansabdar's rank and salary
Sawar	The number of cavalymen a mansabdar must maintain
Jagir	Revenue assignment given as salary
Jagirdar	Holder of a jagir
Watan jagir	Homeland assignment returned to a defeated ruler
Zabt	Akbar's survey-based revenue system
Zamindar	Mughal term for any revenue intermediary
Sulh-i kul	"Universal peace" — Akbar's policy of tolerance
Farman	A royal order
Turani	Turkish noble
Ain-i Akbari	Volume 3 of the <i>Akbar Nama</i> ; administrative and statistical

2-MINUTE RECAP

1. **Descent: Genghis Khan** (mother's side), **Timur** (father's side). They **rejected "Mughal"** (massacre, Uzbek association) and **celebrated Timurid** ancestry — in paintings pairing each ruler with Timur.
2. **Babur**: ruler at 12, driven out by **Uzbeks**, took **Kabul 1504**, won **Delhi and Agra in 1526** using cannon.
3. **Succession was coparcenary, not primogeniture** — every son a claimant, so every succession a war.
4. **Rajput policy**: marriage alliances (**Kachhwaha–Amber, Rathor–Marwar**) and, for the resisting **Sisodiyas of Mewar, defeat without humiliation** and lands returned as **watan jagir**.
5. **Nobility deliberately mixed** — Turanis, Iranis, Indian Muslims, Afghans, Rajputs, Marathas — all enrolled as **mansabdars**.
6. **Zat** = rank and salary; **sawar** = cavalry obligation, with men **registered** and horses **branded**; **jagir** = revenue assignment.
7. **Jagirdars ≠ muqtis** — they **did not live in or govern** their jagirs, holding **only revenue rights** while serving elsewhere.

8. **The jagirdari crisis:** more mansabdars (29 → 79 at 5,000 zat), shrinking real revenue, long waits and short tenures → **maximum extraction** → **"the peasantry suffered tremendously."**
 9. **Zabt** — **Todar Mal's** 10-year survey, revenue circles, crop-wise rates — **but not in Gujarat and Bengal.**
 10. **Zamindar** covered **all intermediaries**; when zamindars and peasants **of the same caste** allied, revolts **challenged the empire from the end of the 17th century.**
 11. **Akbar Nama** by **Abul Fazl**, three volumes; **Ain-i Akbari** is volume 3 and is exceptional for its **statistics.**
 12. **Sulh-i kul** — "universal peace"; room even for **"beliefs, good and bad"**; **"the road to intolerance was closed."**
 13. **Nur Jahan (Mehrunnisa)** married Jahangir in **1611**; **silver coins** struck in her name; she issued **farmans** under her own seals.
 14. **445 of 8,000 mansabdars took 61.5% of imperial revenue** — wealth coexisting with glaring poverty, and **too little left with peasants and artisans to invest in productivity.**
 15. **The empire's own officers** became the rulers of **Hyderabad** and **Awadh** — Chapter 8 begins here.
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Test Yourself

Prelims style

1. Consider the following statements about the mansabdari system:
 1. *Zat* determined a mansabdar's rank and salary.
 2. *Sawar* indicated the number of cavalrymen he was to maintain.
 3. Jagirdars personally administered their jagirs. → *1 and 2 only. Most jagirdars **never resided** in their jagirs.*
2. The *zabt* revenue system —
 1. was based on a survey of crop yields, prices and areas cultivated.
 2. was introduced by Todar Mal.
 3. was applied uniformly across the whole empire. → *1 and 2 only. It was **not** used in provinces such as Gujarat and Bengal.*
3. Why did the Mughals emphasise Timurid rather than Mongol descent? → *Genghis Khan's memory was associated with massacres and with the Uzbeks, their rivals; Timur had captured Delhi.*
4. Consider the following pairs:
 1. Sisodiya Rajput — Mewar
 2. Rathor Rajput — Marwar
 3. Kachhwaha — Jodhpur → **1 and 2 only. The Kachhwahas ruled **Amber (Jaipur)**; Jodhpur was Marwar, the Rathors.**
5. The *Ain-i Akbari* — → *Is the third volume of the Akbar Nama by Abul Fazl, dealing with administration, household, army, revenues and geography, and notable for its statistical detail.*
6. In the twentieth year of Shah Jahan's reign, the highest-ranking mansabdars — → *Numbered 445 out of about 8,000 and received 61.5% of the empire's estimated revenue.*

Mains style

7. "*Sulh-i kul* was both an ethical commitment and an instrument of imperial integration." Discuss. **(250 words)**
8. Examine the jagirdari crisis as a structural explanation for Mughal decline. **(250 words)**

9. "The Mughal Empire was rich, but its producers were poor — and that is why its prosperity did not compound." Comment. **(250 words)**

10. Compare the *iqta* and *jagir* systems as solutions to paying an imperial elite. **(150 words)**

Self-check (out loud, no notes):

- Define *mansab*, *zat*, *sawar*, *jagir*.
- How did a jagirdar differ from a muqti?
- Explain the jagirdari crisis in four steps.
- Who devised *zabt*, on what basis, and where did it fail?
- Quote the key phrase from Jahangir's description of *sulh-i kul*.
- What material evidence shows Nur Jahan's authority?
- State the 61.5% statistic and say why it mattered economically.